

**IRAQ****Capital city:** Baghdad**Area:** 168,753 sq miles
(437,072 sq km)**Population:** 25,200,000**Official language:** Arabic,
Kurdish**Major religions:** Muslim
95%, other 5%**Government:** Multi-party
democracy**Currency:** New Iraqi dinar**Adult literacy rate:** 40%**Life expectancy:** 63 years**People per doctor:** 1,667

IRAQ

IRAQ IS ONE OF THE LARGEST and most powerful countries in the Middle East. Most of its people are Muslim and Arabic speaking. There are also around 4 million Kurds living in the north. Aside from the fertile plains of the Tigris and Euphrates rivers, most of Iraq is mountainous or covered in desert. Only about a sixth of the country is suitable for farming and much of Iraq's food is imported. Since Iraq became a republic in 1958, it has experienced great political unrest. In 2003, a US-led international force invaded Iraq and removed its dictatorial leader, Saddam Hussein. The country is now moving towards democracy.

This ziggurat is in Ur, once a thriving city in Mesopotamia.



The fertile crescent extends through Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, Israel, and into northern Egypt.

**MESOPOTAMIA**

Many ancient peoples settled in Mesopotamia (part of which is now Iraq) because it lay in the fertile crescent of land formed by the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. The area has many ancient ruins, including stepped, pyramidlike structures called ziggurats, found at Babylon and Ur. The steps led to a temple at the top.

**BAGHDAD**

Baghdad, the capital of Iraq, lies on the banks of the Tigris River. It is the largest city in Iraq and the country's center of business and government. A city of contrasts, it is a mixture of ancient mosques, modern high-rise buildings, and packed bazaars. Baghdad has been a center of Islamic culture for more than a thousand years.

**SADDAM HUSSEIN**

In 1979, Saddam Hussein became leader of Iraq. Under his dictatorship, many Iraqis who opposed his rule, especially Kurds, were savagely killed or imprisoned. During the invasion of Iraq in 2003, statues of the dictator were pulled down by his victorious opponents.

The huts, or mudhifs, are made of reeds bound tightly together.

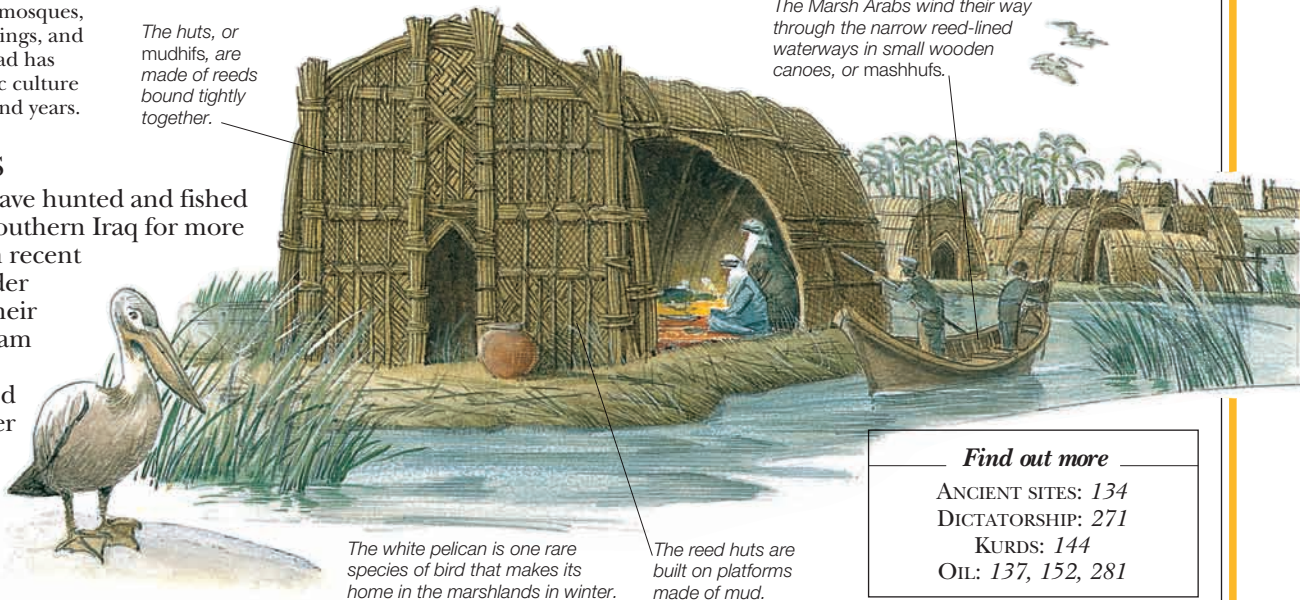
**PIPING OIL**

Iraq's most important natural resources are oil and natural gas. Oil production began on a large scale in 1945 and now dominates the economy. Because Iraq has only a short stretch of coastline along the Persian Gulf, it relies on pipelines through Turkey, Syria, and Saudi Arabia to export its oil.

The Marsh Arabs wind their way through the narrow reed-lined waterways in small wooden canoes, or mashhufs.

MARSH ARABS

The Marsh Arabs have hunted and fished in the marshes of southern Iraq for more than 5,000 years. In recent years they were under threat because of their opposition to Saddam Hussein, whose government drained the marshes to water crops elsewhere. This endangered both the Marsh Arabs and the region's unique wildlife.



The white pelican is one rare species of bird that makes its home in the marshlands in winter.

The reed huts are built on platforms made of mud.

Find out more

ANCIENT SITES: 134

DICTATORSHIP: 271

KURDS: 144

OIL: 137, 152, 281